

Adapting Your Words to Your Readers

Chapter 3

The Importance of Adaptation (choosing the right words)

- Readers occupy particular organizational, professional and personal contexts who do not have same levels of vocabulary, knowledge, or values
- Readers might have different cultures
- Choose the right words that communicate clearly

Learn about the Readers

- Visualize your reader
 - How they think
 - What they know
 - Educational level
 - Culture
- Write for them once you have sorted these out

Adapting to Multiple Readers

- Write in such a way that your different readers can find and understand the parts of message that are of value to them
- Follow and admire the rules for effective wording

Suggestions for Selecting Words

- Use familiar words
- Prefer short words
- Use slang and popular cliches with caution
- Use technical words and acronyms appropriately
- Use precise language
- Select words for appropriate usage
- Prefer active verbs
- Avoid overuse of camouflaged verbs

Rule 1: Use Familiar Words

- First, have a look at some unfamiliar words
 - Endeavor
 - Demonstrate
 - Ascertain
 - Underpin
 - Distinction
 - Initiate

Rule 1: Use Familiar Words Use Familiar Words (Cont.)

Unfamiliar Words	Familiar Words
Endeavor	Try
Demonstrate	Show
Ascertain	Find out
Underpin	Support
Distinction	Difference
Initiate	Begin

Rule 1: Use Familiar Words (Cont.)

More examples of unfamiliar words:

- Determine
- Furnish
- Entrepreneur
- Paradox
- Perform
- Discontinue

Rule 1: Use Familiar Words (Cont.)

Unfamiliar Words	Familiar Words
Determine	Decide
Furnish	Give
Entrepreneur	Businessman
Paradox	Inconsistency
Perform	Do
Discontinue	Stop

Rule 2: Use Short Words

- This machine has a tendency to develop excessive and annoying audio symptoms when operating at elevated temperatures
- This machine tends to get noisy when it turns hot
- Purchase of new fleet is not actionable at this junction
- Buying new trucks is not practical now
- We must leverage our core competencies to maximize our competitiveness
- Relying on what we do best will make us the the most competitive

Rule 2: Use Short Words (Cont.)

- The proposed enhancement is under consideration
- We are considering your suggestions
- They agreed to the proposition to undertake a collaborative venture
- They agreed to work with us
- Prior to accelerating productive operation, the supervisor inspected the machinery
- Before Speeding up production, the supervisor inspected the machinery

Rule 3: Use Technical Words and Acronyms Appropriately

Familiar Initials	Unfamiliar Initials
IBM	SEO (Search Engine Optimization)
CEO	CRM (Customer Relationship Management)
MTO	CCO (Chief Customer Officer)
GM	CIPD (Chartered Institution of Personnel Development)

Rule 3: Use Technical Words and Acronyms Appropriately (cont.)

- Annuity
- Sunk Cost
- Opportunity cost
- Blue Ocean Strategy
- Monkey management
- Transactional leadership

In Class Assignment

- Involve discussing with your neighbors and using examples other than those in the slides, identify 4 technical words that would communicate effectively to others in the field but would need to be clarified for those outside the field.



Rule 4: Use Precise Language

Abstract	Concrete
A significant loss	A 59% loss during the winter
Excellent pass rate	100% pass rate in the BBA program
A very good university	One of the top 100 universities
I will see you soon	I will see you tomorrow at 10 am
A number of people have decided to quit	12% of the employees have decided to leave the job

What do you think about the following comment?

- “I am not going to simplify my writing of my readers. That would be talking down to them. Plus, if they can’t understand English, that’s their problem”- evaluate this comment.

Rule 5: Prefer Active Verbs

Passive	Active
1. Your report was read by the president	?
2. The profit and loss statement is prepared by the accountant every month	?
3. It is suggested by us that you clean the element in warm and soapy water	?
4. The policy was enforced by the committee	?

Rule 5: Prefer Active Verbs (cont.)

Passive	Active
1. Your report was read by the president	1. The president read the report
2. The profit and loss statement is prepared by the accountant every month	2. The accountant prepares the profit and loss report everyday
3. It is suggested by us that you clean the element in warm and soapy water	3. We suggested that you clean the element in warm and soapy water
4. The policy was enforced by the committee	4. The committee enforced the policy



Rule 6: Select Words for Appropriate Usage

- Affect vs. Effect
- Fewer vs. Lesser
- Continual vs. Continuous
- Farther vs. Further

Rule 7: Don't use the wrong IDIOMS

Faulty Idioms-

1. Authority about
2. Comply to
3. Different than
4. Equally as bad
5. In accordance to
6. In search for
7. Listen at
8. Based off of

Don't use the wrong IDIOM (Cont.)

Faulty Idioms	Correct Idioms
1. Authority about	1. Authority on
2. Comply to	2. Comply with
3. Different than	3. Different from
4. Equally as bad	4. Equally bad
5. In accordance to	5. In accordance with
6. In search for	6. In search of
7. Listen at	7. Listen to
8. Based off of	8. Based on



Rule 8: Avoid discriminatory Writing

- Discriminatory words refer to those words that do not treat all people with equal respect
- They refer negatively to the groups of people by gender, race, nationality, sexual orientation, age, or disability
- Eliminate discriminatory words from your dictionary

Nondiscriminatory Writing

- Don't use sexist words
- The women are undermined by the sexist words
- In our society, the women are meant to work in the home while the men are considered as the decision makers and key players

Use Gender-Neutral Words

- Avoid masculine pronouns such as he, his, and him
- Every person has **HIS** own point of view
- The typical UAP student eats **HIS** lunch at the cafeteria

Use Gender-Neutral Words (Cont.)

- Establish a neutral expression (he or she, he/she, S/he, him or her, him/her)
- Every person has **HIS or HER** own point of view
- The typical NSU student eats **HIS or HER** lunch at the cafeteria

Use Gender-Neutral Words (Cont.)

- Alternatively, restructure the sentence and eliminate the offending words
 - The typical UAP student eats lunch at the student cafeteria

Your turn

Establish the neutral expression:

- When a customer needs service, it is his right to ask for it
- If a student scores well, he is placed on our list

Use Gender-Neutral Words (Cont.)

Sexist Words	Gender-Neutral Words
Man-made	?
Manpower	?
Congressman	?
Businessman	?
Chairman	?
Fireman	?

Use Gender-Neutral Words (Cont.)

Sexist Words	Gender-Neutral Words
Man-made	Manufactured
Manpower	Personnel/ Worker/ Employee
Congressman	Member of congress
Businessman	Businessperson/ Entrepreneur
Chairman	Chairperson
Fireman	Firefighter

Your turn

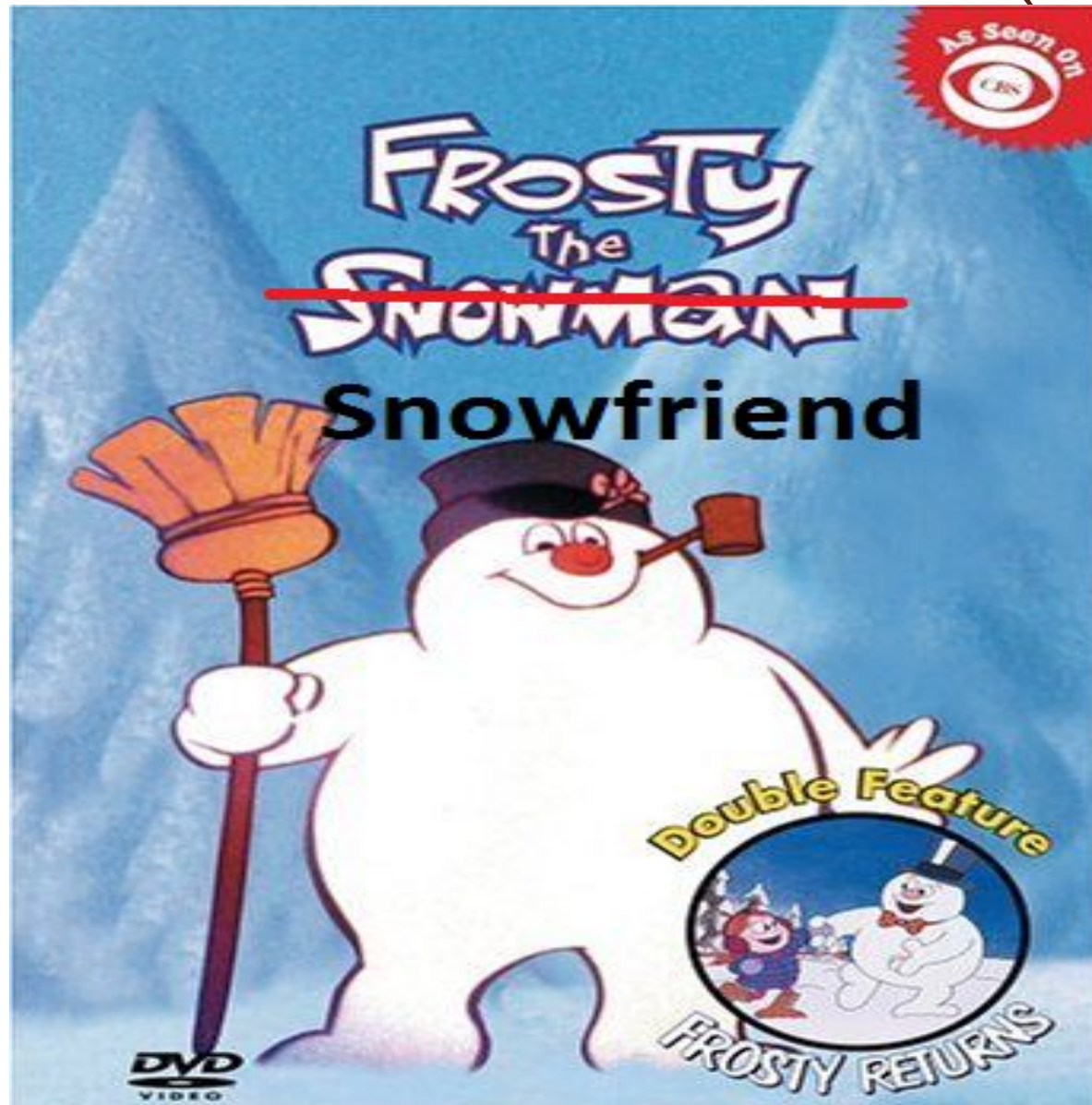
Convert the following words into gender-neutral words

1. Policeman
2. Freshman
3. Patrolman
4. Camera man
5. Snowman

Please visit the following site for more examples

<http://www.writinghelp-central.com/gender-neutral.html>

Use Gender-Neutral Words (Cont.)



Nondiscriminatory Writing

- Avoid the words affected by race, nationality and disability
- Race-
 1. A hard-working African-American
 2. White Chappell is a low-income area which is consisted of British-Bangladeshi
- Age-
 1. Young doctor
 2. Elderly/ Senior Citizen
- Disability-
 1. Deaf, Blind



Thank You